When once we had abandoned the Transcaspian railway, evacuated the Caucasus and surrendered control of the Caspian Sea itself, and, still more, when our troops had retired before Russian aggression in Ghilan... it was obvious that a helpless Persia had no alternative but to negotiate with an enemy firmly established on Persian soil.[53]

Moshaver ul Mamalek, the Persian envoy who had been dispatched to Moscow following the Enzeli affair, certainly believed that, should Persia refuse to sign a treaty with the Bolsheviks, it would 'be attacked from all sides, Gilan, Azerbaijan and Khorassan. The English will not make any resistance...'[54] By signing the treaty, the Persian government hoped to convince the Russians to remove their troops from northern Persia.[55]

Indeed, it would seem that many in the Persian government remained suspicious of the Bolshevik regime. The Persian consul general in Georgia believed that 'All their promises are false, and they are only trying to deceive us',[56] while Norman noted that Zia'eddin 'fears Russia, and his nervousness regarding her policy appears to increase as Soviet Minister draws nearer to Tehran'.[57] Hussein Ala, the Persian minister in Washington told the US State Department that the signing of the treaty 'does not mean that our country wishes to come under Moscow's influence or accept Bolshevik doctrines. We were obliged to reach a modus vivendi with a powerful neighbour because of territorial closeness.'[58]

Whatever the reasons that motivated the Persian government the reaction of the British government to the Soviet-Persian Treaty, particularly the Foreign Office, was somewhat surprising. In contrast to the virulent anti-Bolshevik rhetoric that Curzon had used in 1918–1919 to justify his Anglo-Persian Agreement, the Foreign Office response to this turn of affairs was muted. When the treaty was published in the Manchester Guardian in March 1921, Oliphant simply described the document as 'absurd'. As he pointed out (somewhat amusedly), if Article I of the agreement (which renounced all prior treaties between Russia and Persia) was to be taken literally, it would mean the surrender to Persia of practically all of the Caucasus.[59] In the opinion of George Churchill, the treaty was 'probably